with expensive software kept far from the consumer; until Hirokazu Kato of Nara Institute of Science and Technology, Japan released the ARToolKit to the open source community. The ARToolKit was a platform for creating augmented reality applications. It used video tracking capabilities and virtual object interaction, and provided 3D graphics models that could be overlaid on any OS platform. Smartphones were not in the picture at the time; the Flash based AR applications required a simple hand-held device with a camera and a stable Internet connection. Prof. Bruce H. Thomas of the Wearable Computer Lab at the University of South Australia created the first ever Augmented Reality video game, ARQuake. You needed your laptop in a backpack, GPS, gyroscopes, a head-mounted display and voila! The world around you changed into a game arena, with monsters roaming about in your vicinity in real time. You didn't need a joystick; you could move about in the real world and destroy the virtual monsters. The game still exists as a prototype to this day and unfortunately, no plans to commercialise it exist as of now.


ARQuake

A few years later in 2008, Augmented Reality apps came to your smartphones, where you could finally enjoy this mindblowing technology. With applications like Wikitude and Layar which pioneered the smartphone app market, the environment around you was suddenly made "clickable". These AR apps use your smartphone/tablets' camera, GPS, compass and other sensors to overlay information on the camera feed to your device. When ARToolkit was ported to Adobe Flash, Augmented Reality was made possible through your desktop browser and the webcam.

In February 2009, at the TED conference, Pattie Maes and Pranav Mistry presented their augmented-reality system- SixthSense. Their prototype consisted of a pocket projector, a mirror and a camera contained in a pendant-like device that a user wore around his neck. Since the camera is positioned on the user's chest, it augments everything